As Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla walks through the narrow alleys of a slum in Kota, his parliamentary constituency, to enquire about the health of young mothers and their newborns, his stern facial expression—usually on display while he is chairing the House proceedings—gives way to a benevolent smile. Always up for promoting a public cause, from mobile kitchens to free clothes for the poor, Birla found a new mission when Kota's JK Lone Hospital reported a high incidence of infant deaths in December 2019. "Often, a newborn is weak because of the mother's poor health, which in turn is due to the lack of adequate medical advice during pregnancy," says Birla, whose wife Amita, a gynaecologist, helped him understand that maternal and infant mortality in India are not always related to poor health infrastructure or doctors' negligence.

**SUPOSHIT MAA ABHIYAN**
**FOUNDED: 2020**
Kota, Rajasthan

Thus was born the Suposhit Maa Abhiyan (or a well-nourished mother campaign) to identify undernourished women, mostly expectant mothers, and provide them with nutrition kits along with regular medical check-ups for a few months after the delivery. Union minister Smriti Irani launched its first phase on February 29, 2020, after Birla involved social workers and doctors to identify the beneficiaries, who were mostly labourers and domestic helps residing in slums. Seeing the positive results among the 1,000 women covered under the scheme, Birla in May 2022 extended the campaign to cover 3,000 women in the second phase. "We often talk of hunger, but malnutrition is a bigger issue affecting our new generation. Our campaign not only helps improve the health of a woman but also her newborn, besides creating awareness about a healthy diet among the whole family," says Birla, while recalling how the Covid-induced lockdown soon after the launch of the first phase reinforced his belief that improving nutrition can go a long way towards building a healthy generation.

The Janani Social Work and Health Sanstha Team is his leading partner in this effort. To identify the beneficiaries, it held camps at 26 places, involving health officials and anganwadi workers. Underweight women can easily be identified through physical examination. Nutritionists then work out the curated list of food supplements, including molasses, porridge, ghee and a multigrain diet. A monthly kit weighs about 15 kg and costs about Rs 1,000. In cases of severe anaemia, extra supplements are given. The kits are delivered for up to a year, often beginning in the third month of pregnancy. Some private doctors have joined the effort by offering free consultations at their clinics.

"What I found encouraging is that almost all deliveries have turned out to be normal, with two-thirds of the babies weighing above normal," says Birla, who wants to bring down his constituency's maternal and infant mortality rates to the lowest across India. "But I also want this pilot project to be rigorously evaluated and then implemented all over the country. As the Speaker, I urge other elected representatives to take up similar programmes in their constituencies as well." It's definitely an effort worth emulating. ■



**FEEDING CHANGE**
Speaker Om Birla meets beneficiaries of the Suposhit Maa Abhiyan

**HAPPINESS MANTRA**

***"Knowing that my efforts are keeping mothers and children healthy makes me extremely happy"***

**OM BIRLA, Lok Sabha Speaker and founder, Suposhit Maa Abhiyan**